

A herd of spotted deer in one of the wildlife sanctuaries of Uttar Pradesh

Photo By: **Prakhar Kishan**

OFFBEAT TRAILS IN UTTAR PRADESH

Mukesh Meshram, Principal Secretary, Tourism & Culture, Government of Uttar Pradesh talks about the amazing but lesser-known destinations of the state

Tell us about the lesser-known destinations of Uttar Pradesh?

There are a lot of lesser-known destinations in Uttar Pradesh which offer some amazing experiences to visitors. Ecotourism is a prominent offering in these spots which lie in the lap of nature. We have organized them into several ecotourism circuits for the convenience of visitors. These circuits have helped us to put the spotlight on the lesser known but equally spectacular regions of the state which lie beyond the popular circuits.

For instance, the Eastern Wildlife Circuit includes the Sohagi Barwa Wildlife Sanctuary in the Maharajganj district bordering Nepal. It boasts a beautiful forest cover and rich flora and fauna. Similarly, the Western Wildlife Circuit showcases lesser-known wildlife destinations like the Amangarh Tiger Reserve in Bijnor, the Shivalik forest range in Saharanpur and the Hastinapur Wildlife Sanctuary.

Also, all these circuits offer multifarious attractions beyond nature safaris. If the Southern Bundelkhand Circuit takes in holy and historic spots like Chitrakoot and Kalinjar, the Suhelwa Wildlife Sanctuary which is part of the Eastern Wildlife Circuit also offers an opportunity to visit the Buddhist destination of Shravasti.

What other upcoming destinations can visitors look forward to?

The Vindhya Forest Circuit offers a mesmerizing experience of the hill tracts of Uttar Pradesh. It includes destinations like the Kaimoor Wildlife Sanctuary, Wyndham Falls, Vijaygarh Fort, Hathinala forests, Jai Prakash Narayan Bird Sanctuary and many more. The Ganges Basin Circuit puts the focus on lesser-known destinations along the banks of India's holiest river, like Narora, Kannauj and Bithoor. The wetlands of Uttar Pradesh attract a host of migratory birds each winter, so we have focused a lot on birding destinations as well. For example, Lakh Bahosi Sanctuary in Kannauj, Vijay Sagar Bird Sanctuary in Bundelkhand, and Bakhira Bird Sanctuary and Parvati Arga Bird Sanctuary in Eastern Uttar Pradesh are all destinations we are promoting actively.

What steps are you taking to develop these destinations and create a comfortable experience for visitors?

We are developing the infrastructure at these destinations. Some circuits like the Terai Tiger Circuit are already well developed with excellent connectivity and accommodation facilities. Other circuits will also be developed along the same lines with a focus on ecofriendly accommodation and experiences. Besides that, we are engaging in a lot of publicity to make tourists aware of these destinations. We have also organized familiarization trips for travel agents and journalists, so they can help spread the word about these amazing attractions. We are optimistic that our efforts will help spread the development of tourism evenly across the state, besides boosting local economies.

FESTIVE SEASON

Madhya Pradesh Tourism is bolstering the tourism season with two enchanting festivals–the pilot edition of the Chanderi Festival and the return of the Gandhi Sagar Festival

Prepare yourself for an exhilarating voyage filled with cultural immersion, wildlife and adventures. Madhya Pradesh has scheduled two vibrant festivals for October and November, ensuring a thrilling blend of glamping, adventurous pursuits and cultural interactions.

CHANDERI FESTIVAL

The first-ever edition of the Chanderi Festival will be celebrated from 5th October at Chanderi in Ashoknagar district. The festival will be inaugurated at the historic Chanderi Fort and will celebrate the culture of the state. A glamping tent city will be set up at the Katti Ghati in Chanderi where visitors can engage in several activities. Maha Aarti will be performed at the Laxman Sagar Ghat. An excursion will be organised for guests to the Pranpur craft village. Activities like DJ nights and light & sound shows, hot-air balloon glow show, vintage car rallies and photography workshops will be conducted. Chanderi's traditional festivities, multi-hued culture, and unique weaving techniques are its major attractions, complemented by serene surroundings and nature tourism.

GANDHI SAGAR FESTIVAL

Asia's first floating festival, Gandhi Sagar Floating Festival's second edition begins on October 27, 2023. This festival promises adventure and beauty amid the Gandhi Sagar Dam's backwaters. Participate in cultural events, sample delicious food, and enjoy star gazing, musical nights, and live performances. Try kayaking, jet skiing, hot-air ballooning, horseback riding, parasailing, and even a jungle safari.

TENT CITIES–YOUR HOME AWAY FROM HOME FOR THREE MONTHS!

During the Adventure Season, both the Chanderi Festival and Gandhi Sagar Festival will provide a unique opportunity to experience the great outdoors. Stay in lavish tent cities nestled in the heart of nature, offering all the comforts of modern living while immersing yourself in the exotic landscapes of Madhya Pradesh. Whether you're a nature enthusiast, an adventure seeker, a culture aficionado, or someone looking to escape the ordinary, the Adventure Season in Madhya Pradesh promises to fulfill all your desires.

So, mark your calendars and visit Madhya Pradesh for a season of adventure, culture and recreation.



